



ACTAI • WEEK 01 • LECTURE 02

Your AI Toolkit

Getting set up and doing real work with AI — today.



Hands-on session • have a tool open to follow along

FROM ORIENTATION TO ACTION

Today: stop talking, start using



Open a tool now

Pick one and have it open beside you for the whole session.



Follow along live

Try every example yourself as we go — don't just watch.



Leave with something

By the end you'll have done real, useful work with AI.

MEET YOUR TOOLKIT

The big three you'll actually use



ChatGPT

The versatile all-rounder. A great default for writing, brainstorming, quick answers, and images.



Claude

Shines on long documents, careful writing, and working through big chunks of text or files.



Gemini

Woven into Google — Docs, Gmail, Search. Handy for research and Google-based work.

All three have free versions · they overlap a lot · and they change fast.

Which one, when?



Big readings, essays, careful analysis

→ reach for Claude



Everyday writing, quick help, images

→ reach for ChatGPT



Anything inside Google — Docs, Gmail, research

→ reach for Gemini



Rule of thumb: pick one, get fluent, then branch out. They overlap and change fast — don't overthink it.

It's a partner, not a search engine



Treating it like Google

- Typing in keywords
- Expecting one perfect answer
- Taking the first reply as final
- Giving it no background



Treating it like a partner

- Having a back-and-forth
- Refining and iterating
- Pushing back: 'shorter', 'try again'
- Giving context and a clear goal

The students who converse get far more out of it than the ones who just search.

WHAT CAN I THROW AT IT?

Six verbs for almost anything



Summarize

long text into key points



Draft

emails, essays, messages



Explain

hard ideas, made simple



Brainstorm

ideas, names, approaches



Transform

notes into tables, formats



Critique

feedback on your work

Build a request from three parts

Context

Who you are and any background it needs.

"I'm a first-year law student..."

Task

Exactly what you want it to do.

"summarize this case in plain English"

Format

Length, tone, and structure.

"under 150 words, in bullet points"

Context + Task + Format = a result you can actually use.

SEE THE DIFFERENCE

Same tool. Different prompt.



VAGUE PROMPT

write something about climate change

Generic and rambling — could be for anyone. You'll probably throw it away.



SPECIFIC PROMPT

Write a 200-word intro for a first-year essay on how climate change affects farming in South Asia. Neutral, academic tone.

Focused, on-topic, right length and tone. A real first draft you can build on.

The only thing that changed was how you asked.

Crunch a long reading down

YOUR PROMPT

Summarize the reading below in 5 bullet points for someone new to the topic. Then list 2 questions it leaves unanswered.

[paste your text]

WHAT YOU GET

- 5 short, plain-language bullets with the core ideas
- 2 follow-up questions to explore further
- Readable in 20 seconds, not 20 minutes

The move: tell it the length, the audience, and the format you want.

Write the email you're dreading

YOUR PROMPT

Write a polite email to my professor asking for a 3-day extension on my essay because I was unwell. Under 120 words, respectful, not over-apologetic. Sign as Sara.

WHAT YOU GET

- A ready-to-send email with the right tone
- Clear ask, brief reason, no rambling
- Easy to tweak one line and send

The move: give it a role, a recipient, a tone, and clear limits.

Make a hard idea click

YOUR PROMPT

Explain how the stock market works to a 12-year-old, using one real-world analogy. Keep it under 150 words.

WHAT YOU GET

- A plain-language explanation, no jargon
- A relatable analogy that makes it stick
- Ask follow-ups until it truly clicks

The move: set the audience level and ask for an analogy.

Beat the blank page

YOUR PROMPT

Give me 15 ways a biology student could use AI in their studies. Mix simple and ambitious, one line each. Then star the 3 easiest to start this week.

WHAT YOU GET

- A long, varied list to react to
- Then narrowed to a feasible shortlist
- Momentum instead of a blank page

The move: ask for quantity first, then have it narrow things down.

Reshape what you already have

YOUR PROMPT

Turn my messy lecture notes below into a clean study sheet: clear headings, key terms in bold, and a 5-question self-quiz at the end.

[paste your notes]

WHAT YOU GET

- A structured study sheet from raw notes
- Key terms highlighted, quiz to test yourself
- Reuses work you already did

The move: AI is brilliant at reshaping content you already own.

AVOID THESE

Five beginner mistakes



Being vague — 'write about X' gets generic mush. Be specific.



Stopping at the first answer — it's a draft — push it to make the next one better.



Giving no context — tell it who you are and what you actually need.



Trusting it blindly — it can be confidently wrong. Check important facts.



Giving up after one bad reply — rephrase, add detail, and try again.

Your first task



Before next class

- Pick one real thing from your courses this week.
- Run it through any tool using Context + Task + Format.
- Try a vague version and a specific version — compare them.
- Post your best result in the Week 1 forum thread.

Note: this is a participation checkpoint that counts toward your certificate.



LECTURE 2 RECAP

You've already started.

You met the tools, learned which to reach for, the partner mindset, the six verbs, and watched a prompt change the result.

Next up — Prompting that works: getting great results on purpose, every time.